

Korea Daily Brief

Friday, September 11, 2026

No. 170 · 2,989 words · 12 min read

RE: Yoon acquitted · OPCON 'no conditions' · Hormuz FM call · Exports +83% · 38N: NK-China link near opening

KOSPI
6,909.91
▼ -1.8%

USD/KRW
1,339.18
— flat

BRENT
\$103.90
▼ -3.5%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 A Seoul court acquitted former President Yoon Suk-yeol in the power abuse case over an ambassador appointment, a rare legal reprieve for the impeached former leader.
- 2 Defense Minister nominee Kang Shin-chul told the National Assembly that Seoul seeks to retake wartime operational control from the US under a 'no added conditions' principle.
- 3 South Korea's exports surged 83 percent in the first ten days of September on semiconductor strength, even as the KOSPI fell 1.76% on US inflation data and rising oil prices.

• TOP STORIES

US-KOREA

Seoul court acquits ex-President Yoon in power abuse case over ambassador appointment

A Seoul court acquitted former President **Yoon Suk-yeol** Friday in the power abuse case stemming from the appointment of a former envoy to Australia, a rare legal reprieve for the impeached former leader. The acquittal does not affect Yoon's ongoing appellate trial on separate charges related to free opinion polls, in which prosecutors sought a four-year prison term on the same day. Yoon was also separately acquitted in a case related to a South Korean marine's drowning.

Yonhap EN · AP · WaPo

US-KOREA

Defense minister nominee Kang Shin-chul: Seoul to retake OPCON under 'no added conditions' principle

Defense Minister nominee **Kang Shin-chul** told the National Assembly that South Korea will pursue retaking wartime operational control from the United States without attaching additional preconditions, aligning with outgoing Minister Ahn Kyu-baek's position that Seoul can defend itself independently. Separately, Vice Defense Minister **Lee Doo-hee** rejected nuclear sharing, independent nuclear development, and US tactical nuclear redeployment in a parliamentary session, pushing back against PPP pressure. The dual statements frame the incoming defense team's posture ahead of confirmation hearings.

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

38 North: New North Korea-China border crossing near the new Yalu River Bridge appears close to opening

Satellite imagery analyzed by **38 North** shows a new North Korea-China road crossing linked to the new Yalu River Bridge at Sinuiju-Dandong appears close to opening. The development follows the March 2026 resumption of Sinuiju-Dandong passenger rail and comes days after Russia's Sep 8 opening of the first road bridge over the Tumen River connecting DPRK and Russia. A new road crossing would provide an additional permanent land route for cross-border trade and potentially dual-use goods flows.

38 North

• OVERNIGHT

US-KOREA Korea's Lee faces pushback as Trump ups pressure over Hormuz deployment — Domestic opposition widening as Trump presses Seoul on naval contribution. · Bloomberg

US-KOREA The political cost of sending Korean forces to Hormuz — FM Cho told Iran counterpart no decision made; domestic political resistance mounting. · Foreign Policy

DPRK Kim Jong Un wants North Koreans to have more state-sanctioned fun — Reuters/KCNA — KCNA directive on leisure follows Wonsan Kalma resort's second short summer season. · Reuters

US-KOREA Seoul rejects nuclear sharing as North Korea threat fuels opposition pressure — Vice Defense Minister rules out US tactical nukes, independent arsenal, and nuclear sharing. · NK News

US-KOREA South Korea's Lee to host Central Asia summit in Seoul next week — Critical minerals and supply chain cooperation top the agenda. · Reuters

ENERGY Red Sea gateway blocked — 'double blockade' of oil routes becomes reality — Houthi seizure of Bab el-Mandeb Strait island compounds Hormuz pressure on Korea's oil supply. · SBS

• STAT OF THE DAY

83%

ROK export growth, first 10 days of September (year-on-year)

Chip-led export surge is driving Seoul's case that economic recovery remains solid even as the KOSPI dropped 1.76% on US CPI data and oil price concerns.

Yonhap English — '(LEAD) Exports up 83 pct in first 10 days of Sept. on chips'

● No appearance (3d since last)

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

- 1. **Kim Jong Un thanks troops deployed to Russia in founding anniversary ceremony** KIM
Kim's founding anniversary speech publicly acknowledged and thanked DPRK troops serving in overseas military operations — the first confirmed public acknowledgment in official KCNA output. — KCNA (NK News)
- 2. **Kim Jong Un wants North Koreans to have more state-sanctioned fun** KIM
KCNA carried Kim's directive on expanding state-approved leisure activities for citizens, including domestic tourism and recreation programming. — KCNA (Reuters)
- 3. **Russia slams UN watchdog for reporting on North Korean nuclear facility**
Russia's representative at the Vienna IAEA session dismissed the agency's report on the new Yongbyon uranium enrichment facility, citing lack of access to North Korea. — KCNA (NK News)

Bottom line: Kim's founding anniversary public thanks to troops in Russia marks the first official KCNA acknowledgment of DPRK overseas military deployments; the post-anniversary period — including today's 10-year anniversary of the fifth nuclear test — historically carries elevated provocation risk at Punggye-ri.

● ROK GOVERNMENT

President + Ministries · Friday, September 11, 2026

국방부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

Nominee declares OPCON retransfer under 'no added conditions' principle

Defense Minister nominee Kang Shin-chul
Defense Minister nominee **Kang Shin-chul** stated in written responses to the National Assembly that Seoul seeks to retake wartime operational control from the US under a 'no added conditions' principle, expressing agreement with outgoing Minister Ahn Kyu-baek that South Korea can defend itself independently. He also identified North Korean regime and military as South Korea's primary adversary.

[Primary](#) [Yonhap EN](#) ↗

외교부 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Foreign Minister calls Iranian counterpart, states no Hormuz deployment decision made

FM Cho Hyun
FM Cho Hyun held phone talks with Iranian Foreign Minister Araghchi, telling Tehran that no decision has been made on a possible ROK deployment to the Strait of Hormuz. Cho stressed Seoul's consistent position that freedom of navigation for all vessels in the strait must be guaranteed.

[Primary](#) [Yonhap EN](#) ↗

국방부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

Vice Minister rejects nuclear sharing, own nukes, and US tactical nuclear deployment options

Vice Defense Minister Lee Doo-hee

Vice Defense Minister Lee Doo-hee told a parliamentary session that South Korea is not considering deploying US tactical nuclear weapons, developing its own nuclear arsenal, or pursuing nuclear sharing with Washington, rejecting calls from the opposition People Power Party for such measures.

[Primary NK News ↗](#)

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Kang Shin-chul NOMINATED

Defense Minister (nominee, pending confirmation)

Kang Shin-chul is before the National Assembly for confirmation hearings as Defense Minister nominee, having submitted written responses on OPCON, nuclear policy, and North Korea threat assessment. He is set to replace Ahn Kyu-baek.

Replaces: Ahn Kyu-baek

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Defense Minister nominee Kang Shin-chul submitted written responses on OPCON, nuclear sharing, and North Korea policy

National Defense Committee

Nominee Kang declared OPCON retransfer under 'no added conditions' and identified North Korea as primary adversary in written answers to PPP lawmaker Yoo Yong-won, ahead of his confirmation hearing.

ROK ruling DP and opposition PPP clash over real estate tax reform at economic interpellation

National Assembly (general session / interpellation)

Deputy PM and Finance Minister Gu Yun-cheol defended the government's plan to strengthen property tax burdens on non-resident single homeowners, framing it as incentivizing residence over speculation; PPP called it punitive.

• US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

Steel and aluminium stay at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, leaving no single baseline reciprocal tariff. Section 301 is now the primary prospective tariff vehicle; ROK Trade Minister Kim Jeong-kwan is in Washington to finalize the bilateral investment framework.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

WATCH THIS DATE

next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES

Steel & Aluminum	SECTION 232	50%
Copper	SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts	SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives	SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)	25%
Pharmaceuticals	SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION	0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST	0%

NEW THIS WEEK

South Korea nears agreement worth over \$100 billion in US investments — WSJ/Reuters >\$100B

New deal

Trade Minister Kim Jeong-kwan traveled to Washington on Sep 11 to finalize investment negotiations; Reuters reported Seoul is nearing an agreement on a package worth over \$100 billion in US investments, citing a WSJ report. ROK GOVERNMENT / US GOVERNMENT · REUTERS / SBS

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

• BUSINESS & ECONOMY

MACRO · YONHAP ENGLISH

ROK exports surge 83% in first 10 days of September on semiconductor strength

South Korea's exports jumped 83 percent year-on-year in the first ten days of September, with chips the primary driver, according to Korea Customs data. The surge supports the finance ministry's assessment of solid export-led recovery, even as the KOSPI fell 1.76% on US CPI surprise.

MACRO · YONHAP ENGLISH

KOSPI falls 1.76% as US August core CPI beats expectations, oil prices rise

Seoul shares dropped 1.76 percent Friday as rising oil prices and US August core CPI data — up 0.3% month-on-month, above the 0.2% consensus — stoked Fed rate-hike fears. Brent crude fell 3.47% on the day to \$103.90, reflecting Middle East supply disruption concerns.

MANUFACTURING · YONHAP ENGLISH

Samsung E&A wins 4.7 trillion-won fertilizer EPC contract in Saudi Arabia

Samsung E&A secured a 4.7 trillion-won EPC contract for a fertilizer facility in Saudi Arabia, one of the largest Korean construction awards in the Middle East this year.

• NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

TRILATERAL · NIKKEI

South Korea's AI diplomacy needs Japan in the room — Nikkei Asia

A Nikkei opinion piece argues Seoul's AI diplomacy — including the July 2026 San Francisco AI Summit — requires deeper Japan engagement to maximize regional leverage and avoid duplicative bilateral frameworks with the US. The argument reinforces the Camp David trilateral AI cooperation commitments.

RUSSIA-KOREA · RUSSIA-SANCTIONS · YONHAP ENGLISH

ROK trade minister seeks UK exemption from Russian LNG sanctions

Trade Minister Kim Jeong-kwan asked his British counterpart for an exemption from UK sanctions on Russian LNG, reflecting Seoul's continuing dependence on Russian energy and the difficulty of full sanctions alignment with Western partners. The request comes as the Red Sea blockade and Hormuz tensions compound Korean energy supply concerns.

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

38%

▼ 2 pts vs Sep 4

Gallup Korea · week of 2026-09-11



RULING
Democratic

39%

OPPOSITION
People Power

25%

INDEPENDENTS

26%

Gallup Korea Spotlight August 25-27, 2026

Security Policy Priorities and Lee Approval Record Low: Lee Jae-myung's approval fell to 42% (lowest since inauguration) with disapproval first crossing 50%; the weekly poll covered security priorities including OPCON transfer, denuclearization, inter-Korean military balance, and the proposed merger of three military academies.

Discourse: Lee Jae-myung approval at record low of 38% (Gallup Korea, week of Sep 11), coinciding with domestic debate over Hormuz deployment and OPCON timeline.

• UPCOMING

Oct
3

National Foundation Day (개천절)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9

Hangul Day (한글날)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10

Workers' Party founding day

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

• THE WIRE

DPRK

NK NEWS

US and South Korea agree to establish WMD information-sharing system at annual CWMDC meeting

The annual US-ROK Combined WMD Countermeasures Committee agreed Thursday to establish a system for sharing information on North Korea's nuclear, chemical, and biological threats, and discussed strengthening joint response mechanisms.

NK NEWS

North-South Korean language divergence accelerating under Kim Jong Un, with 45,354 new words added to DPRK dictionary

The expanded 2017 DPRK 'Great Dictionary of the Korean Language' added 45,354 new words, and the rate of new vocabulary under Kim Jong Un's rule has sharply increased, according to a South Korean lawmaker, widening the linguistic gap between the two Koreas.

TECHNOLOGY

BLOOMBERG

South Korea ramps up espionage law to protect semiconductor trade secrets from China

Seoul is strengthening its industrial espionage statutes targeting theft of chip-related intellectual property, responding to documented cases of Chinese actors acquiring Korean semiconductor know-how. The move aligns with broader ROK efforts to tighten technology security alongside US BIS export control frameworks.

• ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

FM Cho Hyun @FMChoHyun

"I had a phone call with Iranian Foreign Minister Araghchi and discussed the recent Middle East situation, bilateral relations, and protection of our nationals. I emphasized Seoul's consistent position that free and safe navigation of all vessels in the Strait of Hormuz must be guaranteed."

Context: Post confirms the phone call with Araghchi reported in today's Yonhap and Reuters coverage; Cho separately met Uganda's Second Deputy PM on Sep 10 for a Korea-Uganda trade forum.

[View on X](#) →

ROK Ministry of National Defense @ROK_MND

“The Chunmoo multiple-launch rocket system export contract with Croatia — 18 systems and 410 million euros in ammunition — was signed in Zagreb on Sep 10. This is the first large-scale defense cooperation between Korea and Croatia, valued at approximately 640 billion won. A bilateral defense MOU was also signed.”

Context: Defense Minister Ahn Kyu-baek attended the Zagreb signing alongside Croatian Deputy PM and Defense Minister Ivan Anušić; the contract is the first major ROK-Croatia arms deal.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Cho Hyun
ROK Foreign Minister

“No decision has been made on a possible Hormuz deployment. South Korea’s consistent position is that freedom of navigation for all vessels in the Strait must be guaranteed.”

Analyst: Cho made the statement directly to Iranian FM Araghchi in a phone call Friday; the exchange follows the ROK assessment team’s return from UAE on Sep 10 and precedes a National Assembly debate on possible naval contribution.

[Source →](#)

• **SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH**

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

38 NORTH · SEP 11, 2026 — NEW NORTH KOREA-CHINA BORDER CROSSING NEAR OPENING

38 North: New Sinuiju–Dandong road link appears close to opening based on satellite imagery analysis.

Satellite imagery analyzed by 38 North shows the new North Korea-China border crossing — linked to the new Yalu River Bridge — appears close to opening. The analysis follows the March 12, 2026 resumption of the Sinuiju-Dandong passenger rail service after the COVID-era suspension. A new road crossing would provide an additional permanent land route supplementing existing rail.

→ Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border)

38 North – New North Korea-China Link Appears Close to Opening ↗

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.

ALERT ▲

Tumangang–Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind.

imagery as of 2026-09-08

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border)

Sep 11, 2026: 38 North satellite imagery analysis shows the new North Korea-China border crossing (new Yalu River Bridge) appears close to opening.
Mar 12, 2026: Cross-border passenger train service resumed between Sinuiju and Dandong after COVID-era suspension.

imagery as of 2026-09-11

ACTIVITY ▲

Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail.

imagery as of 2026-09-08

7 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-05.

CSIS

GEOPOLITICS AND FOREIGN
POLICY DEPARTMENT

KOREA
CHAIR

Washington, D.C.

You are receiving the Korea Daily Brief as a member of the CSIS Korea Chair distribution list.

[Read online](#)

[Past issues](#)

[Trade reference](#)

This newsletter is automatically generated, so it may contain errors. Please check all information and sources before citing. To report errors or other issues, please contact Andy Lim at alim@csis.org.

[↑ BACK TO TOP](#)